Et Tu Honecker

Relations with West Germany, meanwhile, had also taken a more urgent and direct grip on Honecker's life. As the Soviet Union and West Germany improved ties, Ulbricht permitted a meeting between the head of the GDR's Council of Ministers, Willi Stoph, and Willy Brandt. The East German town of Erfurt became the unlikely scene of the meeting on 19 March 1970, which marked the first-ever face-to-face talks between senior government figures of the FRG and GDR. 'The meeting,' TASS noted, was held at the initiative of the East German government which 'thus demonstrated once more its desire to normalise relations with Western Germany'.1 In a commentary, Neues Deutschland added: 'We have shown this initiative and accommodating attitude because we are earnest in our endeavour to make a contribution to the peace and security of Europe. Now everything depends on the West German Chancellor's adopting a realistic and reasonable attitude.'2 The two sides sought to 'establish normal relations by treaty' and find common interests in areas including road, railway and waterway communications, postal services, simpler trading facilities and financial arrangements. For his part, Stoph would demand recognition for the GDR and reparations payments for the talent lost to the FRG through the exodus of refugees prior to 1961. 'This is a difficult terrain with many obstacles,'3 Brandt explained. He also revealed he had formed a mental picture of Stoph as a man with rigid views, 'I have the impression that he is a man who quite deliberately keeps his own person in the background, far behind the cause he represents … and is therefore a difficult partner in such talks.'4

Desperate to sour the event, it is probable that Honecker helped to arrange for a crowd of East Germans to give Brandt a hero's welcome in front of the Erfurter Hof, an old-style hotel across the square from the railway station. Press reports described folks standing on the sidewalks shouting for 'Willy' – not Willi Stoph, but for Willy Brandt.5 'For a moment,' Brandt recalled in his memoirs, 'they felt free enough to show their feelings. I was moved.' Political observers shrewdly pondered whether events were staged by a